

How Smoking and Nicotine Damage Your Body

You probably know about the relationship between smoking and lung cancer, but did you know smoking is also linked to heart disease, other chronic diseases? Smoking can increase your risk for cancer of the bladder, throat, mouth, kidneys, cervix and pancreas. Thinking about quitting? Look at the facts!

Why should you quit?

- Smoking is the most preventable cause of death and disability in the United States.
- Almost one third of deaths from coronary heart disease are due to smoking and secondhand smoke.
- Smoking is linked to about 90% of lung cancer cases in the United States.
- Smoking rates overall are down, but too many adults still smoke, vape and use other forms of tobacco, especially between the ages of 21 and 34.
- Almost half of U.S. children ages 3-11 are exposed to secondhand smoke.
- On average, smokers die more than 10 years earlier than nonsmokers.
- You can be one of the millions of people who successfully quit every year.

What makes cigarettes so toxic and dangerous?

There are more than 7,000 chemical components found in cigarette smoke and hundreds of them are harmful to human health, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

Carbon monoxide & nicotine: A dangerous duo

Carbon monoxide is a harmful gas you inhale when you smoke. Once in your lungs, it's transferred to your bloodstream. Carbon monoxide decreases the amount of oxygen that is carried in the red blood cells. It also increases the amount of cholesterol that is deposited into the inner lining of the arteries which, over time, can cause the arteries to harden. This leads to heart disease, artery disease and possibly heart attack.

Nicotine is a dangerous and highly addictive chemical. It can cause an increase in blood pressure, heart rate, flow of blood to the heart and a narrowing of the arteries (vessels that carry blood). Nicotine may also contribute to the hardening of the arterial walls, which in turn, may lead to a heart attack. This chemical can stay in your body for six to eight hours depending on how often you smoke. Also, as with most addictive substances, there are some side effects of withdrawal. And some e-cigarettes and newer tobacco products deliver even more nicotine than traditional cigarettes.

Secondhand smoke

Smokers aren't the only ones affected by tobacco smoke. Secondhand smoke and vapor is a serious health hazard for nonsmokers, especially children. Nonsmokers who have high blood pressure or high blood cholesterol have an even greater risk of developing heart diseases when

they're exposed to secondhand smoke. Secondhand tobacco smoke contributes to thousands of premature heart disease and lung cancer deaths. Studies show that the risk of developing heart disease is about 25-30 percent higher among people exposed to environmental tobacco smoke at home or work. Secondhand smoke promotes illness, too. Children of smokers have many more respiratory infections than do children of nonsmokers.

The bottom line

Cigarettes, e-cigarettes and other tobacco products contain many dangerous toxins. The best thing you can do for your health is to quit tobacco entirely. Don't spend the rest of your life chained to a nicotine addiction. Thousands of people kick the habit every year, and you can be one of them. It may not be easy, but you can do it!

Help! I Want to Quit Smoking!

Congratulations on making the decision to quit smoking, vaping or using tobacco! You've made your health a priority, and you should be proud of yourself. But deciding to quit is just the first step. The rest of the path to successfully quitting may not be as easy for you. That's when medicines and other resources may be useful to help you stamp out tobacco for good.

Resources to help you quit

You don't have to do this alone. Many people find support groups and hotlines helpful when quitting tobacco. Sometimes, just knowing that someone understands and shares your struggle can help you stay smoke-free for good.

Private programs

Many hospitals, health care companies and employers offer outpatient and inpatient smoking cessation programs. Insurance may even help with the cost.

What to look for in a cessation program

Cessation programs vary. For instance, some may rely on behavior modification, while others include nicotine replacement products or non-nicotine prescription medications. Always talk to a member of your health care team before starting any medication.

Successful cessation programs share some things in common. Look for programs that are:

Comprehensive. The best programs consider many factors, including your triggers, lifestyle and past efforts to quit. Your family and friends can play a vital role in helping you quit.

Evidence-based. Successful programs rely on proven science. Seek out approaches that include clinically proven methods, such as counseling, behavioral therapies and consultations with a health care professional.

A good fit for you. For some people, messages of support by phone, email or text are crucial, while others respond better to in-person support groups. Set yourself up for success by choosing a program with the right features for you.

Medicines to help you quit

When used correctly, there are several different medicines that can help you on your path to quitting. Some treatments are aimed at reducing the side effects of quitting, such as headaches or irritability, while others help by making nicotine cravings less severe. You might need a nicotine replacement medicine, a non-nicotine replacement medicine or a combination of both. Talk to a member of your health care team about the best treatment plan for you.

Nicotine replacement medicines

Nicotine replacement treatment usually lasts between two and three months. Even though you can buy several of these products over the counter, you should still talk to a health care professional first about which type is best for you. Remember, you should NOT use nicotine replacement medicines if you keep smoking, vaping or using other tobacco products. Using both at the same time can be dangerous.

1. Nicotine chewing gum or lozenges

- For decades, nicotine gum has helped people successfully quit smoking. You can buy the gum or lozenges in a drug store without a prescription. Just be sure to read the directions on the packaging and follow the recommended dosages.
- Chew a piece of gum or suck a lozenge every one to two hours while you're awake, but don't use more than 20 pieces per day of 4 mg gum or lozenges or 30 pieces per day of 2 mg gum or lozenges. The number of pieces you use each day should decrease over time.
- Don't drink coffee, orange juice, soda or alcohol for 15 minutes before or while chewing a piece of gum or sucking a lozenge. These drinks make the nicotine replacement less powerful.
- If you don't use nicotine gum or lozenges correctly, you may have side effects such as discomfort in your mouth and throat.
- You may need to use nicotine gum or lozenges for about three months.

2. Nicotine patch

- You don't need a doctor's prescription to buy a nicotine patch.

- Some brands are available in 5, 10 and 15 mg strengths; others come in 7, 14 and 21 mg strengths. What strength you should start with depends on how much you currently smoke. Look for recommended doses on the packaging to help you determine where to start.
- Over time, you'll taper off your dosage and start using lower-strength patches based on your brand's recommended schedule.
- Wear the patch on your chest or high on your arm.
- Put on a new patch every 16 or 24 hours. If you have trouble sleeping or have disturbing dreams, remove the patch before you go to bed and put on a new one when you wake up.
- There's no need to change your daily routine. You can shower, swim and enjoy all your favorite physical activities while wearing the patch.
- Side effects may include redness and soreness under the patch. To help reduce side effects, you should change the location of the patch each day.

3. Nicotine spray

- Unlike the first two nicotine replacement options, you will need a prescription from your doctor to buy nicotine spray.
- The spray goes in your nose one or two times per hour when you're awake.
- The spray may cause coughing, runny nose or watery eyes during the first week or two. These side effects may go away over time.
- You may need to use nicotine spray for up to six months, but you'll start to taper off at or before three months.

Non-nicotine prescription medicines

Bupropion hydrochloride is a medicine for depression, but it also helps people quit smoking. Brand names include Zyban®, Wellbutrin®, Wellbutrin SR® and Wellbutrin XL®. This medication is also available as a generic. Varenicline is another generic medicine that can help reduce the cravings for nicotine and its pleasurable effects on the brain.

These are two commonly prescribed smoking-cessation medicines. For your information and reference, we have included generic names as well as brand names to help you identify what you may be taking. However, the American Heart Association does not recommend or endorse any specific products. If your prescription medication isn't on this list, remember that a health care professional and a pharmacist are your best sources of information. It's important to discuss all of the drugs you take with a member of your health care team and understand their desired effects and possible side effects. Never stop taking a medication and never change your dose or frequency without first consulting a member of your health care team.

- Both medicines block the flow of chemicals in the brain that make you want to smoke.
- Both medicines come in pill form. You start with a low dose and gradually increase up to the full dose.
- It takes about a week for these medicines to work, so you need to start them before you actually quit smoking or vaping.
- Each of these medicines may interact differently with other medicines you're taking. Make sure your health care team and pharmacist have a complete list of all your medications, including over-the-counter drugs, supplements and herbal medicines.
- You may need to use a non-nicotine prescription medicine for 7 to 12 weeks or longer. Follow your health care team's recommendations.
- When you get ready to stop taking a non-nicotine prescription medicine, you may need to taper off, gradually decreasing the dose before you completely stop.
- People with a seizure disorder or predisposition to seizure should not take bupropion.
- The most common side effects of bupropion are headache, difficulty sleeping, anxiety and dry mouth.
- The most common side effects from varenicline are nausea, difficulty sleeping and unusual dreams.
- If you experience any unusual changes in mood or behavior while taking either of these drugs, you should stop taking the medicine and call your health care professional right away.

Whichever method you choose to quit, know that you're taking an important step toward a healthier, longer life. Stick with it and keep trying if you relapse along your journey. It's worth it.